



Logged by Score, Reclaimed by Chance

Auditing Whether a Library Lost-Property Claim-Likelihood Index Predicts What Gets Recovered

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The problem

Since the library's Lost & Found Index began scoring every logged item's claim-likelihood at intake, cataloguing staff work the high-score shelf first. Does the score that decides what gets catalogued first also predict what gets reclaimed, or just which items wait longest before the bin?

What we set out to test

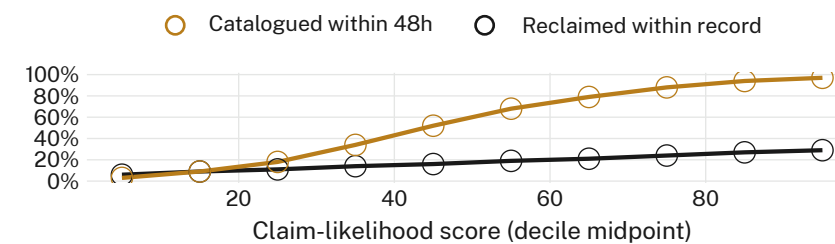
- Test whether claim-likelihood score predicts eventual reclaim
- Compare cataloguing turnaround against the same score
- Audit the binning window against actual claims received

Study design

- n = 926 items · 14-month intake register · front desk
- claim-likelihood scored 0–100 at intake; reclaim and bin outcomes traced to closure
- score thresholds and 21-day binning window held constant; no manual override

Findings

Score tracked cataloguing order closely ($r = 0.79$) but reclaim only weakly ($r = 0.22$). Items scoring below 20 were binned a median nine days after intake, claimed or not.



Catalogued-within-48h rate rose from 3% to 97% across the score range ($r = 0.79$, $n = 926$); reclaim rate rose only from 6% to 29% over the same range ($r = 0.22$).

Implications

The Index sorts the shelf, not the outcome — staff work what scores well, and the binning window compounds the sort before any claimant arrives. A claim-likelihood score that predicts staff attention more than public recovery is measuring itself. Next: trial a cataloguing order blind to score, holding the binning window constant.

Selected references

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3. FitzGerald, G., Jelinek, G. A., Scott, D., & Gerdzt, M. F. (2010). Emergency department triage revisited. *Emergency Medicine Journal*, 27(2), 86–92. doi:10.1136/emj.2009.077081
4. Lum, K., & Isaac, W. (2016). To predict and serve? *Significance*, 13(5), 14–19. doi:10.1111/j.1740-9713.2016.00960.x
5. Sabel, R., Hanke, M., & Ntuli, B. (2026). The Rack Forgets Slower Than the Rider: Cataloguing Why a Campus Bike-Stall Tag Outlives Its Claim. Office of Research Outputs, Slop University. doi:10.5555/slop.etwfmk

De-identified intake log only; no claimant approached before closure; binning window pre-registered.

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“The charger scored an 8% claim-likelihood. It was catalogued nineteen days after the umbrella scored 61%.”

926 items logged over 14 months; the score predicted cataloguing order three times more closely than it predicted reclaim.